



Voice of the Viet Cong

Nguyen Thi Binh (center) crashed the peace talks on behalf of the National Liberation Front (the political arm of the Viet Cong) and eventually got a place at the table. A skilled diplomat, she served two terms as the vice president of Vietnam in the postwar era.

Death and disorder

The peace talks were held against a backdrop of chaos in the streets of Paris that nearly toppled Charles de Gaulle's government. Student demonstrations coupled with widespread general strikes brought the entire country to a standstill for the better part of two weeks in the middle of May.

Talks stalled for four months, until November, when Johnson agreed to suspend all bombing and end Operation Rolling Thunder. In December 1968, US Secretary of Defense Clark M. Clifford remarked that delegates should "stop squabbling." Despite claiming that the US was not at all at fault for the slow progress, he made a good point: "each day and each week that they delay, more men are dying on the battlefield of South Vietnam."